



Summer School Concept Note on Transformative Approaches in Agrosilvopastoral Systems

Committee on Forestry Working Group on Dryland Forests and Agrosilvopastoral Systems

Jordan, September 2023

Context

Drylands and rangelands account for the sustenance of over 2 billion people in the world. Today, the existence of drylands and agrosilvopastoral systems are exponentially plagued by factors like climate change and unsustainable land use. Additionally, the variation in drylands means that we cannot employ a one size fits all solution to maximize the lifespan and potential of drylands.

The Food and Agriculture Organization's (FAO) Working Group on Dryland Forests and Agrosilvopastoral Systems (COFO WG) is a subsidiary body of the Committee on Forestry (COFO). Established in 2016, it aims to develop a comprehensive understanding of dryland forests and agrosilvopastoral systems and to promote the scaling up and adoption of good practices for their protection, sustainable management and restoration, while enhancing and contributing to environmental and socio-economic resilience and sustainable livelihoods. For more information on the COFO WG and its progress, please see [here](#).

In the COFO WG's [workplan for 2022- 2024](#), members recognized the importance of partnering with universities and research institutes in contributing to managing dryland resources effectively. There is a big gap between awareness and the interventions to combat the problems, especially on how to operationalize a sustainable approach to dryland management interventions.

As a result, our approach to building resilient drylands is to train champions. Champions are needed to advocate and promote transformational changes in the management of dryland agrosilvopastoral systems. Champions can facilitate the creation of a shared vision and help make sustainable innovations known. Most importantly, dryland sustaining communities need champions to support the wave of transformation in dryland policymaking and management.

Summer School

On the occasion of the [COFO WG's](#) 3rd session which will be hosted by the Jordanian government in September 2023, we would carry out a summer school to train champions on operationalizing the approach to building resilient drylands and providing the intel for dryland planning and work. This initiative comes as a follow-up step to the eLearning course published in March 2023. This course highlights the [transformative approach](#) to building climate resilient dryland forests and agrosilvopastoral production systems.

Objectives

The summer school aims to train practitioners on the transformational approach to dryland resilient systems and build on their capacities to implement it. The objectives are:

- ◆ To bring together 20-25 dryland planners and practitioners to assess the contribution of their current and planned actions in drylands and rangelands and to steer them towards long-term sustainability and transformation; and
- ◆ Effectively train participants to create contextual solutions to address the core issues in transforming agrosilvopastoral systems and to clearly define cross-cutting indicators of their progress.

Target Participants

Dryland foresters and silvopastoral practitioners, planners and policymakers need to work together to advocate for and promote transformational change in the management of dryland production systems. The cyclical nature of their interactions makes it important to identify and uplift their voices. Practitioners define the core issues in dryland forest and agrosilvopastoral systems management. Planners and policymakers make decisions to eradicate these issues, and practitioners execute accordingly. We are targeting such champions because together they accelerate the necessary action for these systems to continue to provide goods and services to their communities in a sustainable way. Partners will select 20-25 participants based on motivation, capacities, potential impact, and English proficiency while considering gender and geographical balance.

Program Structure

The Summer School will combine theoretical concepts with practical insight from case studies and one-day fieldwork. The courses are another step for the COFO WG to address the need for champions in dryland communities. The summer school will last four days and will be delivered in English, conducted as back-to-back lessons. Trainees - or champions - will have the chance to discuss work on case study data sets provided by trainers. To join this program, participants will be required to complete the eLearning course on building climate-resilient dryland forests and agrosilvopastoral production systems found on the [FAO elearning Academy](#) website. The FAO elearning Academy is dedicated to contributing to the sustainable economic and social advancement of member countries. It does through the transfer of competencies, development of expertise and promotion of innovation to strengthen both institutions and human resources. Proof of completion is required and is in the form of a digital badge certification.

The Role of Partners in Building Capacity

Partners will work closely with FAO and COFO WG steering committee to design the program. The role of partners is important to identify the relevant modules that build an understanding of agrosilvopastoral systems, identify tools to identify the gaps in execution, and innovate contextual solutions to these gaps. Partners have innovation experience and have initiated transformations in agrosilvopastoral systems through their work. They will also be in the participants' selection committee for this program.

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